FARMLIFE

KCFB KINGS COUNTY FARM BUREAU

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July 2025 Water Update: Budgets, Penalties, and the Race to Stay Local

From pumping fees to policy drafts, every GSA in the Tulare Lake Subbasin is being asked to do more with less. Here's what happened this month.

by Julie Martella

Across the Tulare Lake Subbasin, July was marked by budget discussions, policy revisions, and an increasing sense of urgency. Each GSA faces pressure to demonstrate measurable progress without overburdening landowners. However, the path to implementation is littered with trade-offs, and the cost of accountability is no longer just theoretical.

Why the Urgency Around Well Mitigation?

Of all the tasks laid out by the State Water Board, well mitigation is at the top of the list. It's not just a public health concern; it's the clearest sign of whether a GSA is doing the hard work of managing human impacts during groundwater declines.

Across the region, GSAs are diligently working to design well mitigation programs, each in their own way, but all with the same goal: readiness. The Kings County Farm Bureau's legal challenge has temporarily paused state-imposed fees, creating a narrow window for GSAs to build well mitigation programs, draft budgets, and prepare outreach strategies.

Mid-Kings River GSA: Addressing Budgets and Penalties

The Mid-Kings River GSA met three times in July to finalize its budget, revise its well mitigation plan, and advance a detailed groundwater allocation policy. With just one staff member currently managing operations, the GSA is under pressure to expand its capacity while keeping policy implementation on track and stakeholders informed.

The committee spent much of July evaluating funding options to meet SGMA implementation requirements. Discussions included potential Prop 218 assessments, pumping fee structures, and long-term strategies to support legal, technical, and outreach costs. While nothing has been finalized, the GSA is working to develop a budget that reflects both the operational reality and the very real financial strain already facing local growers. They are seeking a path forward that is practical, equitable, and doesn't add to the burden more than it must.

A parallel track of meetings focused on the allocation policy, which will define how water is distributed, credited, and enforced across the basin. Drafting this policy has raised several key questions:

- Whether cities like Hanford should pay pumping fees, and

"GSA Roundup" continued on page 14

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Introducing First Fridays: Lunch, Conversation, and Community

By Kings County Farm Bureau

A new monthly tradition brings Kings County's rural community together—one plate and one conversation at a time.

Starting in September, the Kings County Farm Bureau is launching a new monthly tradition: First Fridays, a community lunch for farmers, ranchers, rural landowners, and neighbors who care about the future of agriculture in Kings County.

Each month, we'll open our doors and serve a free lunch at the KCFB office in Hanford. This isn't just about the food. It's about connection. It's about taking a break from the workday to hear what's happening, share your perspective, and walk away better informed about the issues shaping our region.

The idea behind First Fridays is simple: create a space where ag conversations can happen in a way that's natural, honest, and respectful of your time. No PowerPoint presentations. No drawn-out meetings. Just a short, relevant update from Farm Bureau leadership or a guest speaker, followed by open Q&A and informal conversation.

First Topic: GSA Updates in the Tulare Lake Subbasin

Water continues to be one of the most critical challenges facing agriculture in our region. That's why the very first, First Friday, on September 5, will focus on updates from local Groundwater

"First Fridays" continued on page 13

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Reliable | Trusted Resource

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KCFB Executive Director's Report

Dusty Ference

Since our last update, I've been working on a number of key issues that affect growers and landowners across Kings County. From SGMA to air quality to the local economy, your Farm Bureau is actively engaged in defending agriculture and pushing for common-sense policy.

Strengthening State-Level Ties

In mid-July, I met with representatives from the Governor's Central California Office of External Affairs to discuss labor, budget concerns, and SGMA. We agreed to stay in contact and serve as mutual resources. These relationships matter; they help ensure our local issues aren't forgotten in Sacramento.

Groundwater Lawsuit: Clarifying the Mission

I recently met with several South Fork Kings-area growers to walk through our lawsuit against the State Water Resources Control Board. The discussion focused on what our case addresses, and just as importantly, what it doesn't. This lawsuit remains one of the most important actions we've taken to protect local groundwater control and avoid costly, top-down state intervention.

The lawsuit is still active but is currently awaiting an appellate court ruling. This is good news for the Tulare Lake subbasin as it saves landowners a second irrigation season's worth of pumping and well registration fees that would have otherwise been paid to the State Water Resources Control Board (SWRCB). To date, the effort has saved growers an estimated $100 per acre plus well registration fees.

Tulare Lake Talk

We've fielded several inquiries about rumors of restoring the Tulare Lake. We've intentionally held comments to avoid speculation, but we're keeping close tabs on the situation. If a formal proposal emerges, we'll bring it to the board and our membership.

Air Quality: Keeping Watch on New Rules

The Valley remains in nonattainment under the EPA's 2015 ozone standard, and regulators are under pressure to show progress. While no new actions have been proposed yet, we're tracking developments to ensure new rules don't unfairly impact local farms

Leadership at the County Level

After more than a year of dormancy, the Kings County Ag Advisory Committee reconvened. We're already working to make sure grower concerns are prioritized in upcoming County discussions.

Dairy Permits Temporarily Paused

Due to staffing shortages, Kings County has been flagged by the State Attorney General's Office as out of compliance with CEQA. As a result, all dairy permits are temporarily on hold. The County is working to resolve the issue, and we're pushing for a speedy resolution. We've voiced concern to County staff and offered support in prioritizing ag-related reviews.

Economic Impact Report Underway

We're teaming up with Kings EDC to update the Agricultural Economic Impact Report, which will quantify ag's role in supporting jobs, local revenue, and community vitality. This report will help tell our story with data, not just anecdotes, showing exactly how farm jobs, purchases, and local taxes keep Kings County running

Looking Ahead

Late July and August will bring several opportunities to discuss the lawsuit with industry groups, local governments, and growers.

As always, if you have questions or concerns, I'm just a phone call away.

Dusty Ference

Dusty Ference
Executive Director

Stay hopeful, My friends

By Geoff Vanden Heuvel, Director of Regulatory and Economic Affairs
Geoff@MilkProducers.org This essay first appeared in the Milk Producers Council Weekly Friday Report July 11, 2025

As citrus growers in California's Central Valley grapple with significant water quality and quantity issues, the need for precise fertilization and irrigation practices is more critical than ever. Currently, citrus growers in the valley lack access to a specialized, free decision-support tool that could guide them in making informed decisions about fertilizer application. The crops' physiological characteristics are unique amongst commodities grown in the valley, adding a layer of complexity to developing such a tool.

According to a recent study conducted at University of California-Davis funded by the California Department of Food and Agriculture (CDFA FREP), fertilizer rate decisions in citrus orchards should be based on nutrient export in expected yield while fertilizer application rates and timings should be based upon the pattern of nutrient accumulation in fruits. Yield potential determines fertilizer strategy and there is a large negative impact on overall efficiency that occurs in years or orchards of poor yield in which standardized fertilization strategies are used. Therefore, fertilizing according to predicted yields will dramatically enhance nutrient use efficiency. The methodology used in this research allowed the researchers to estimate the annual amounts of nutrients that field grown orange and mandarin trees absorbed and allocated to above ground organs improving nutrient use

Vanden Heuvel continued on page 14

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AG NEWS IN BRIEF

DWR Releases Draft Guidelines on Limiting Subsidence

On July 24, the California Department of Water Resources released a draft Best Management Practices document for public comment that will help local groundwater agencies to limit land elevation subsidence in California's groundwater basins that are regulated and managed under the Sustainable Groundwater Management Act. Many of California's groundwater basins, particularly in the Central Valley, are affected by subsidence, which occurs when excessive pumping causes soil particles to collapse and compact the earth, lowering the land elevation. Subsidence can damage critical infrastructure, including canals, pipelines, wells, and levees. DWR is accepting comments on the draft document until Sept. 22 and will also hold in-person meetings to review the document and collect feedback from the public. Meetings will be held in Delano on Sept. 9, Clovis on Sept. 10, and Willows on Sept. 11. Additional information about the document and instructions for submitting comments can be found on DWR's website. Farm Bureau will be reviewing the document and may provide written comments.

Senate Environmental Quality Committee Advances AB 1264 on Ultra-Processed Foods

Assembly Bill 1264 on ultra-processed foods passed the Senate Environmental Quality Committee but left key concerns unresolved, including liability and unclear definitions of ultra-processed foods. Discussions now move to Senate Appropriations, where California Farm Bureau will continue to engage.

Federal Hiring Freeze Extended

Federal hiring freeze extended through Oct. 15 as budget reviews continue and agencies face funding cuts. Billions in reductions have stalled hiring across departments.

Dairy Group Announces Plans to Phase Out

Artificial Food Dyes in Ice CreamThe International Dairy Foods Association pledges to remove certified artificial dyes from 90% of U.S. milk-based ice cream by 2027. The move aligns with consumer trends and pressure from the Make America Healthy Again movement.

A Republican lawmaker seeks new rules for immigrant workers. Will Trump listen?

As President Donald Trump pursues a goal of deporting millions of undocumented immigrants, State Sen. Rosilicie Ochoa Bogh is urging him to carve out options for essential workers. Ochoa Bogh, a Redlands Republican, wrote to Trump, Speaker Mike Johnson and Senate Majority Leader John Thune, asking them to issue "expedited work permits to the millions of undocumented immigrants who are considered essential workers, such as farmworkers who provide critical services." The effort marks a shift for Ochoa Bogh, who had long viewed immigration as a federal matter. CalMatters.

Beef prices have soared in the US — and not just during grilling season

Anyone firing up the grill this summer already knows hamburger patties and steaks are expensive, but the latest numbers show prices have climbed to record highs. And experts say consumers shouldn't expect much relief soon either. The average price of a pound of ground beef rose to $6.12 in June, up nearly 12% from a year ago, according to U.S. government data. The average price of all uncooked beef steaks rose 8% to $11.49 per pound. But this is not a recent phenomenon. Beef prices have been steadily rising over the past 20 years because the supply of cattle remains tight while beef remains popular. Associated Press.

Tulare County dairy rebounds after recovering from bird flu

At least one dairy in Tulare County has made a full recovery this summer, a year after many in the region suffered losses from bird flu. Blake Wilbur, whose Tulare dairy has 1,600 milking Jersey cows, saw about a 25% reduction in milk production over a two- to three-week period last fall. "We, fortunately, did not lose many, if any, cows. Dairies with Holsteins suffered worse, and those that got bird flu during the summer heat fared much worse," Wilbur said, noting that his dairy's milk production had not only returned to normal this year but surpassed last year's levels, likely due to favorable weather. "Our cows have bounced back," Wilbur told Ag Alert® in a field report.

Grasshopper damage, losses down as infestations decline

Grasshoppers and Mormon crickets, which in past years traveled great distances and destroyed tens of millions of dollars of Northern California crops, have emerged again this year, although farmers say there's been a small reprieve. During the past several years, grasshopper populationswere so thick that "the cows had their eyes shut walking across the meadows," Plumas County rancher Susy Pearce said. The infestations forced her to spend upwards of $20,000 in pest control from 2021–2023. Pearce said she has seen some grasshoppers this year, "but nothing to panic about."

Foundation provides programs, services for California farmworkers

Joe Garcia, president of the California Farmworker Foundation, founded the organization in 2016 to improve farmworkers' quality of life. A child and grandchild of farmworkers, Garcia said he was motivated to start CFF after observing a lack of political will to solve problems impacting farmworkers. "This inspired me to establish a foundation aimed at addressing the needs of our farmworker communities," he told Ag Alert®. Today, the biggest challenge facing California farmworkers, he said, is the federal government's mass deportation program. "As an organization, our greatest responsibility is to continue standing alongside farmworkers and our communities, offering our support and education," Garcia said. "We aim to be a reliable resource they can trust."

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Lemoore farmers unhappy with lack of representation on groundwater agency

By Monserrat Solis *Editor's note: Monserrat Solis covers Kings County water issues for SJV Water through the California Local News Fellowship initiative.*

Growers in northwestern Kings County are fed up with a lack of representation on their groundwater agency and what they say has been an excessively slow process to get their voices heard.

The board of the South Fork Kings Groundwater Sustainability Agency (GSA) currently has five seats. It has been working since May to add two more to represent the northern portion of the GSA near Lemoore.

Because the five existing seats are held by government agencies, the process to change the board configuration has been slow, said Johnny Gailey, manager of the GSA.

But a document to initiate the change has been making the rounds to those agencies, which include the City of Lemoore, Empire Westside Irrigation District, Kings County, Stratford Irrigation District and Stratford Public Utility District.

"It's being circulated back and forth between attorneys of the different agencies and there are still edits being made to it; the draft is not final," Gailey said during the GSA's July 17 meeting.

That didn't mollify growers.

"Sometimes I wonder why we're meeting to be honest with you," said Frank Coelho Jr., chair of the GSA's grower advisory group at its July 10 meeting. "We should stop all meetings until we get that representation."

Growers Gary Quintel and Julie Freitas agreed.

"Yeah, I didn't even want to come to the last (grower) meeting," Freitas said.

Growers have also been hesitant to comply with GSA policies that they haven't had a more direct hand in creating.

That includes registering their wells' locations, depths and production amounts, something the GSA has been working to gather with limited success.

Quintel said he hasn't registered his wells specifically because of the lack of representation. Other growers shared that sentiment during the July 10 growers advisory meeting.

"I think we should make it clear that people are hesitant because they don't have representation (on the board)," Coelho Jr. said.

As of July 17, 283 wells in the GSA have been registered, 101 of those are domestic. That's about 28% of the area's wells, according to Gailey.

Well registration for South Fork Kings landowners was due July 1. There is no penalty for late registration.

The GSA held two well registration workshops in March to help landowners register their wells through the GSA's web-based platform.

South Fork Kings, like many GSAs in the Tulare Lake subbasin, has established metering and registering policies in an attempt to keep local control under the Sustainable Groundwater Management Act (SGMA).

South Fork Kings Grower advisory members Steve Jackson (L), Kevin Ruble, Frank Coelho Jr., and Michael Newton and manager Johnny Gailey. Monserrat Solis / SJV Water

SGMA requires overdrafted areas to establish plans to bring aquifers into balance by 2040 by a combination of increasing groundwater recharge and reducing pumping.

Last year, South Fork Kings was one of five GSAs in the Tulare Lake subbasin placed on probation by the state Water Resources Control Board for lacking an adequate groundwater plan.

Under probation, farmers must meter and register wells with the state as well as report all extractions. Probation also requires farmers to pay the state an annual $300-per-well registration fee, plus $20 per acre foot pumped. The state has said that money is needed to administer the region during probation.

Those probationary sanctions, however, are paused in the Tulare Lake subbasin pending litigation.

South Fork Kings Groundwater Sustainability Agency

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New Online Tool Will Help California Growers Meet Regulatory Requirements and Production Goals

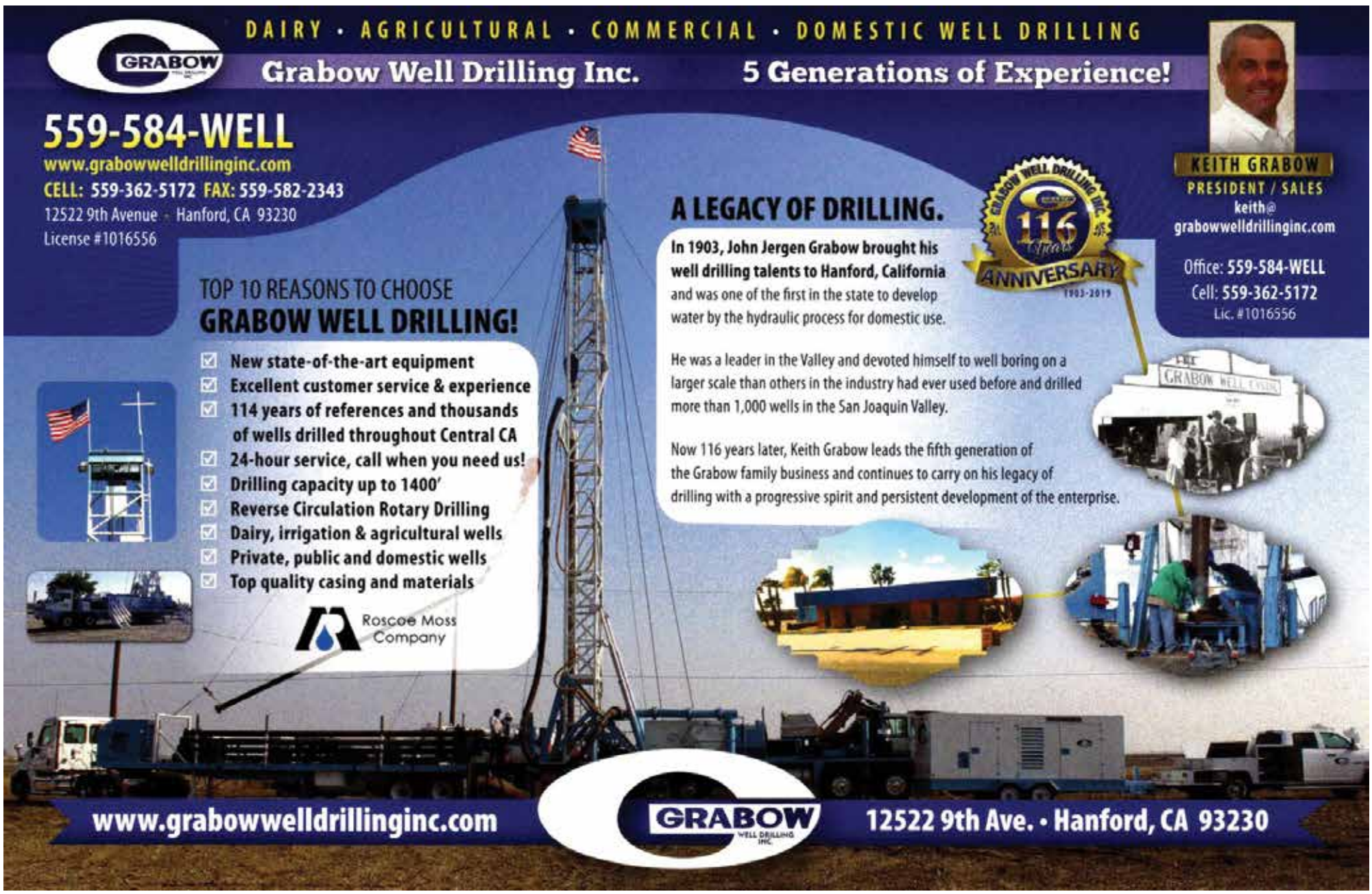
Doug Amaral

As citrus growers in California's Central Valley grapple with significant water quality and quantity issues, the need for precise fertilization and irrigation practices is more critical than ever. Currently, citrus growers in the valley lack access to a specialized, free decision-support tool that could guide them in making informed decisions about fertilizer application. The crops' physiological characteristics are unique amongst commodities grown in the valley, adding a layer of complexity to developing such a tool.

According to a recent study conducted at University of California-Davis funded by the California Department of Food and Agriculture (CDFA FREP), fertilizer rate decisions in citrus orchards should be based on nutrient export in expected yield while fertilizer application rates and timings should be based upon the pattern of nutrient accumulation in fruits. Yield potential determines fertilizer strategy and there is a large negative impact on overall efficiency that occurs in years or orchards of poor yield in which standardized fertilization strategies are used. Therefore, fertilizing according to predicted yields will dramatically enhance nutrient use efficiency. The methodology used in this research allowed the researchers to estimate the annual amounts of nutrients that field grown orange and mandarin trees absorbed and allocated to above ground organs improving nutrient use efficiency from around 50% up to 90%. Thus, knowing the dynamics of nutrient uptake during the season is a requirement to allow the management of the timing of nutrient supply with nutrient needs and to avoid nutrient losses, especially N-Nitrate.

To make this information accessible to growers, a new project funded by CDFA FREP will aim to develop a free decision-support tool that will guide farmers in making informed decisions about irrigation and fertilizer application. This project builds off years of research, experimentation, and software development efforts and will culminate in the development of three new citrus-specific modules for UC's CropManage online platform (oranges, mandarins, and lemons). This project stands to positively impact a diverse group of thousands of citrus growers in California's Central Valley, as California citrus growers supply over 90% of the nation's fresh citrus, and export to over sixteen foreign countries, in harvests valued at over $2 billion per year according to USDA. 75% of that production is in two Central Valley basins, the San Joaquin Valley and Tulare Lake Basin (also referred to as the Southern San Joaquin Valley), where growers are often farming in nitrate-affected areas with intense competition for groundwater resources.

The potential impact of this initiative is significant. By providing citrus growers with access to a refined decision-support tool, this project can lead to increased adoption rates, resulting in more efficient fertilizer and water use. This, in turn, enhances the likelihood of regulatory compliance with the ILRP and SGMA and contributes to the long-term sustainability of California's citrus production. Ultimately, this project not only addresses the immediate needs of citrus growers but also supports the broader goal of preserving the quality and quantity of California's water resources for future generations.



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Ag Commissioner's Compliance Report

Jimmy Hook, Agricultural Commissioner/Sealer

California's history with the use of Transform on Cotton for the control of Lygus

In May of 2013 the Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) approved Transform 50WG (active ingredient (ai) sulfoxaflor), which included the use on cotton. However, in September of 2015 the U.S. 9th Circuit Court vacated EPA's approval citing the lack of data on bee health. This was reinstated in October of 2016 for some of the original crops, not including cotton, pending further studies on the pollinators.

In 2017 California growers applied for a Section 18 exemption for the use of Transform WG on cotton for the treatment of Lygus bugs and Western Lygus bugs. Section 18 of the Federal Insecticide, Fungicide, and Rodenticide Act (FIFRA) authorizes the EPA to allow unregistered use of a pesticide for a limited time if EPA determines that an emergency condition exists. An "emergency condition" is defined as an urgent, non-routine situation that requires the use of a pesticide. This provides a limited time use of a pesticide product (not registered or not registered for that use) to control the emergency when there are no other feasible alternatives. This request was granted and was requested for the next four years. Transform retained a Section 18 exemption from 2017-2020.

In 2019, the EPA fully reinstated the use of sulfoxaflor on cotton in the U.S., based on updated data indicating lower environmental risks. But despite the federal approval, California continued to face restrictive policies and relied on Section 18 exemptions for use. December of 2021 it was ruled by a superior court that California Department of Pesticide Regulation (DPR) violated environmental laws when they approved the use of sulfoxaflor without sufficient pollinator review. This banned the use of it statewide.

Lygus bugs, also called tarnished plant bugs, are some of the most damaging pests to cotton, especially in the mid-south and western U.S. They use their mouths to pierce and suck juices from cotton squares and small bolls, which reduces yields and raises production costs. The most effective way to manage them is with Transform WG insecticide, which helps control lygus bugs while protecting cotton yield and fiber quality.

Transform WG acts on the nicotinic acetylcholine receptors (nAChRs) in insects, disrupting neural function and leading to quick knockdown and mortality. There are several advantages to the use of this pesticide. It is effective against Lygus with minimal issues; it is compatible with Integrated Pest Management (IPM) and beneficial insect conservation; and offers an alternative mode of action in resistance management programs. However, while Transform is relatively safe for many natural enemies, it can be toxic to bees if sprayed during active foraging. This can be mitigated by applying late in the day or early morning; avoid applications during bloom when bees are most active; and follow pollinator protection label requirements.

In May of 2025 an application for a Certificate of Emergency Registration for Transform CA, ai sulfoxaflor, was submitted by the California Cotton Ginners and Growers Association (CCGGA) for the counties of

Merced, Madera, Fresno, Tulare, Kings, Kern, Imperial, and Riverside. After reviewing the application, DPR concluded that there is an urgent pest problem with no suitable alternative to using Transform CA to control Lygus bugs in cotton. After reviewing the application, it was approved and signed by the Director of Pesticide Regulation, Karen Morrison, on June 13, 2025.

Under a federal law called FIFRA, there are special ways to allow the use of pesticides in unusual situations when the regular approval process doesn't work fast enough or doesn't apply. Here is a summary of how they differ. Crisis Exemption (Certificate of Emergency) is a quick fix for emergency pest problems when there is no time to wait for full EPA approval. A Section 18 Emergency Exemption is a temporary permission to use a pesticide that isn't normally allowed for that specific use. A Section 24(c) Special Local Needs Registration allows a state to approve a new use for a pesticide to meet a local need. The most common are Section 18's and Section 24(c)'s, the Crisis Exemption is a rarity.

Kings County is the biggest cotton growing county in California. The health of this crop is not only important to the growers themselves but also to the county and the industry. With this Certificate of Emergency growers will be able to protect their crops for a healthier harvest in the fall. However, there are quite a few requirements that go along with this exemption. One of them is that it is treated as a restricted material, where the applicator is required to submit a Notice of Intent (NOI). The NOI is required to have specific information on it as well. They are also required to fill out a special supplement that states complete acreage to be treated along with the total amount of product to be used. There is a special label they will have to have at the application site along with the DPR cover letter. Kings County inspectors are available for any questions you have about the requirements of Transform CA. Please contact our office at 559-852-2830.

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Federal Funding Spurs New Flashpoint in Battle Over California High-Speed Rail

Federal involvement in the California High-Speed Rail project has reached a critical inflection point. In mid-July 2025, U.S. Transportation Secretary Sean P. Duffy announced that approximately $4 billion in federal funding would be revoked. The decision followed a compliance review by the Federal Railroad Administration (FRA), which concluded that the California High-Speed Rail Authority (CHSRA) had failed to meet key milestones. Nearly $15 billion has been spent over 16 years with no high-speed track in operation.

Citing escalating costs, now estimated at over $130 billion, up from an original $33 billion, and an absence of a complete financing plan or credible schedule for completion, Duffy said, "We have to pull the plug." According to the FRA, the state did not demonstrate "adequate capacity to fulfill the terms of the grant," despite repeated extensions.

California officials, including Governor Gavin Newsom, strongly objected to the move, calling the decision "illegal and politically motivated." The state is expected to pursue legal action to retain the funding. Meanwhile, CHSRA officials point to progress: 171 miles of infrastructure are under development, more than 50 major structures have been completed, and grade separations are underway. They argue that the FRA's termination undermines decades of planning and investment.

Impacts in the Central Valley

The Central Valley has borne the brunt of construction impacts, even as the project's benefits remain speculative. This includes Kings County, where Kings County Farm Bureau (KCFB) has consistently opposed the rail from its inception. The organization's concerns have centered on the loss of prime farmland, fragmentation of operations, and disruption to local infrastructure, all without a clear or direct benefit to the agricultural community.

KCFB's position has remained unchanged since 2008: the high-speed rail project disproportionately burdens rural communities while promising benefits that remain largely out of reach for those footing the cost. Many Kings County farmers have faced years of uncertainty due to land acquisitions, legal disputes, and construction disruptions.

The recent federal funding revocation reinforces long-standing skepticism from KCFB and others in the region, who have questioned the project's feasibility and fairness.

The Funding Picture

The loss of $4 billion in federal support represents nearly 25% of all federal allocations to date. The remaining funds have come from state general obligation bonds (approved under Proposition 1A in 2008) and California's cap-and-trade program, which currently generates approximately $1 billion per year for CHSRA. Even with that stream, the Authority still faces an estimated $7–10 billion funding gap for completing the 171-mile Central Valley segment from Merced to Bakersfield.

Governor Newsom has proposed extending California's cap-and-trade program beyond 2030 to maintain support for the rail system. Still, that proposal is likely to meet resistance in both the legislature and among stakeholders, particularly in rural counties where support for the project has always been thin.

KCFB's Perspective

For KCFB, the issue goes beyond funding. KCFB continues to advocate for infrastructure that serves the needs of rural communities and protects productive farmland. In their view, high-speed rail has not met those criteria. Instead, it has diverted resources, displaced agriculture, and overpromised results for more than 15 years.

The organization has not called for the reallocation of funding to specific alternatives but has consistently urged state

High Speed Rail continued on page 14

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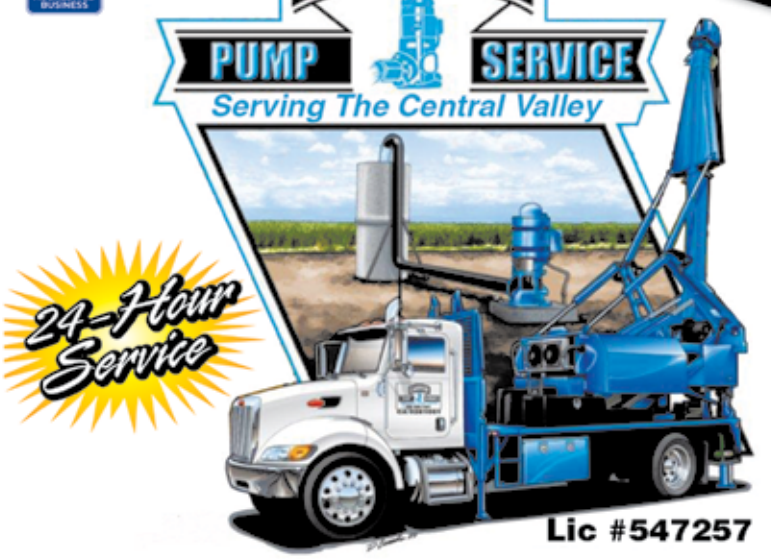

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Kings County Rural Crime Report

Contributed by Detective Santos

In the month of July, the Rural Crimes Unit received information that an animal rights group named Direct Action Everywhere (DXE), based out of the San Francisco Bay area, had posted on their Facebook page that they would be coming to Kings County on July 15, 2025, to protest against animal cruelty. The post was asking the public and members to "take action regarding the illegal dead pile and criminal animal cruelty at Vera Goat Dairy, then proceed to public property near the farm for a vigil to honor the lives lost there." It should be noted that on May 27, 2025, members of DXE allegedly stole (3) kids (baby goats) from the business during daylight hours.

On July 15th, Rural Crimes Unit Detectives were set up inside the Vera Goat Dairy in Stratford, in anticipation that DXE members would make an entry into the business and attempt to steal goats. Rural Crimes Unit Detectives were prepared to make arrests for trespassing if entry was made. Later that morning, approximately 30-40 DXE members protested outside the District Attorney's Office and then walked over to the Sheriff's Office to protest outside. I ultimately spoke with two members of DXE privately and heard their concerns and allegations of animal abuse, which were unfounded based on my investigation. They were also warned that if any DXE members made unlawful entry into the business, they would be arrested for trespassing and theft of goats, should this occur. During my interview, the remainder of the DXE members drove to Vera Dairy and peacefully protested outside of the facility, on the shoulder of the road. Entry was not made, and within a couple of hours, all members left the area without any further incident.

We ask the community to immediately notify the Kings County Sheriff's Office Dispatch if members of DXE arrive at any animal facility in our County to protest. DXE members are typically not considered violent, and protest peacefully but always use caution. DXE members are always looking to verbally engage with business owners or employees, to obtain video footage of the altercation then upload the videos onto their website to obtain "views." We highly recommend you do not fall into this trap and completely avoid them if possible and once again notify our agency immediately.

This month the Rural Crimes Unit was also contacted regarding a stolen Polaris Ranger being sold on Facebook Market Place. We conducted a buy/bust operation and met with the seller in Corcoran as a potential buyer in plain clothes. The Polaris was verified as being stolen by the VIN number and we recovered the vehicle. After speaking with the seller, it was determined he was unaware he had purchased a stolen Polaris, and an arrest was not made.

A wire theft report from a pump in the Kettleman City area was taken. Approximately 100 total feet of insulated wire had been cut and taken between the electrical panel and the pump. The theft and damage were valued at approximately $15,000.

The theft of a yellow, 500-gallon trap wagon was also taken in the Grangeville Blvd and Highway 43 area. The trap wagon was valued at $5000 and the fuel inside was valued at approximately $1600 for a total loss of $6600. The owner had placed an Apple air tag on the wagon, but it appears the suspect(s) located the air tag due to the fact the last day the tag pinged was on the day of the theft. We are actively searching for this trap wagon.

If you have any questions, feel free to call me or any of our unit members at any time.

Detective Santos (559) 904-6893

Detective Estrada (559) 212-7512

Investigator Ward (559) 280-5441

"First Fridays" continued from page 1

Sustainability Agencies (GSAs) operating in the Tulare Lake Subbasin.

We'll also provide a brief update on KCFB's lawsuit against the State Water Resources Control Board (SWRCB). The case challenges the Board's decision to place the subbasin on probation under SGMA. This is a key effort by your Farm Bureau to protect groundwater access and defend the rights of local landowners.

Many growers and landowners still have questions about implementation timelines, well mitigation programs, and what SGMA enforcement actually means on the ground. This is your chance to hear where things stand, and to ask the questions that don't always get answered in boardrooms or public comment sessions.

Who Should Come?

Everyone. If you farm, dairy, ranch, own acreage, or are just part of the rural fabric of Kings County, you're invited. First Fridays is a space for everyone with a stake in agriculture, whether you manage 5 acres or 5,000.

We know that people stay engaged when they feel welcomed. That's the spirit of First Fridays.

Event Details:

- First Friday of every month
- 11:30 AM
- KCFB Office
  870 Greenfield Ave, Hanford
- Lunch is free
- No RSVP required
- Just show up

From the Ground Up

Kings County Farm Bureau exists to advocate, protect, and serve our members, and First Fridays is one more way we're doing that. It's not a fundraiser. It's not a policy summit. It's a table with seats open for conversation, context, and community.

We hope to see you there. Bring a neighbor. Bring a question. Or just bring your appetite.

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efficiency from around 50% up to 90%. Thus, knowing the dynamics of nutrient uptake during the season is a requirement to allow the management of the timing of nutrient supply with nutrient needs and to avoid nutrient losses, especially N-Nitrate.

To make this information accessible to growers, a new project funded by CDFA FREP will aim to develop a free decision-support tool that will guide farmers in making informed decisions about irrigation and fertilizer application. This project builds off years of research, experimentation, and software development efforts and will culminate in the development of three new citrus-specific modules for UC's CropManage online platform (oranges, mandarins, and lemons). This project stands to positively impact a diverse group of thousands of citrus growers in California's Central Valley, as California citrus growers supply over 90% of the nation's fresh citrus, and export to over sixteen foreign countries, in harvests valued at over $2 billion per year according to USDA. 75% of that production is in two Central Valley basins, the San Joaquin Valley and Tulare Lake Basin (also referred to as the Southern San Joaquin Valley), where growers are often farming in nitrate-affected areas with intense competition for groundwater resources.

The potential impact of this initiative is significant. By providing citrus growers with access to a refined decision-support tool, this project can lead to increased adoption rates, resulting in more efficient fertilizer and water use. This, in turn, enhances the likelihood of regulatory compliance with the ILRP and SGMA and contributes to the long-term sustainability of California's citrus production. Ultimately, this project not only addresses the immediate needs of citrus growers but also supports the broader goal of preserving the quality and quantity of California's water resources for future generations.

High Speed Rail continued from page 11

and federal leaders to prioritize investments in water infrastructure, rural road maintenance, and broadband connectivity, which offer immediate and measurable benefits to Kings County's agricultural economy.

Looking Ahead

With federal funds withdrawn and legal action looming, the future of high-speed rail in California is again uncertain. Whether the state can replace the lost funds or restructure the project remains to be seen. What is clear, however, is that for communities like Kings County and organizations like KCFB, the recent developments confirm long-standing concerns. While the state may continue to pursue its vision of high-speed rail, many in the Central Valley remain unconvinced that the cost is justified or that the benefits will ever reach the farm gate.

"GSA" continued from page 1

how to handle urban recharge
- How to calculate and credit private recharge and surface water losses
- Whether de minimis users and public entities should receive native yield
- How to track transitional pumping and set enforceable limits

The GSA also reviewed subsidence concerns, particularly in high-risk zones, and debated how best to manage water levels to avoid triggering State action. A revised version of the well mitigation program is currently in progress, featuring updated intake protocols, revised legal disclaimers, and a clearer appeals process.

South Fork Kings GSA: Focused on Clarity Before Commitment

South Fork Kings GSA held a board meeting on July 17. Well registration currently sits at 28%. No penalties or enforcement mechanisms are in place, and the board discussed the possibility of extending the registration deadline to improve participation.

Outreach is ongoing, and board members acknowledged the need for additional engagement. A draft amendment to the JPA that would add two new seats to the board is currently under review, though it has not yet been adopted.

Meanwhile, the Advisory Committee has been working steadily behind the scenes. The committee reviewed funding needs, mitigation costs, and pumping fees. Cost estimates for domestic well mitigation, monitoring wells, and subsidence tracking were discussed, along with potential Prop 218 rates and groundwater allocations.

Southwest Kings GSA: Budget Finalized, Assessment Lowered

At its July 23 meeting, the Southwest Kings GSA approved a reduced assessment, lowering the rate from $2.50 per acre to $1.50 per acre, citing minimal pumping activity across most of the GSA. The 2025–26 budget was finalized, and the board passed a resolution authorizing Kings County to collect the assessments. A new administrative services contract was also approved, set to begin in August.

Audit completion remains pending, with the 2021 audit still outstanding. The auditor reported that all remaining audits could be completed by the end of 2025. Board members reaffirmed that the GSA is monitoring localized activity but emphasized that basin-wide groundwater pumping is limited this year.

Tri-County Water Authority: Revised Mitigation Plan and a Push for Exemption

At its July 23 stakeholder meeting, the Tri-County Water Authority reviewed the final draft of a revised well mitigation program, which is scheduled to be presented to the board for approval on August 7. The new plan replaces a 2023 version and was developed in direct response to State feedback and SGMA implementation expectations.

The GSA spans both the Tulare Lake and Tule Subbasins and is actively preparing a fee exclusion request on the Tule side. To be eligible, they must show that mitigation programs are not only written but already in motion and working.

The revised plan introduces a two-track model for mitigation support:
- **Domestic Track:** Designed for individual households with dry wells that pose an immediate drinking water concern.
- **Technical Track:** Geared toward larger users, such as small water systems, industrial properties, or municipal infrastructure, that require a different set of solutions.

Tri-County is working diligently to meet State expectations, finalize its mitigation framework, and strengthen its position ahead of potential fee imposition. Their dual-subbasin footprint means the stakes and the deadlines are even higher.

El Rico GSA: No Public Meetings Held in July

As of the publication date, El Rico GSA had not held a public meeting in July. No new updates were available at the time of reporting.

Practical Ways to Stay Engaged

If you've been trying to follow all the moving parts, including budgets, penalties, and mitigation plans, you're not alone. Every GSA in the Tulare Lake Subbasin is under pressure to act, and the window to shape how that happens is closing.

Here's what you can do right now:
- Check your well registration status. Registering your well is an important step, and the best way to obtain accurate, up-to-date data on water use, well locations, and potential problem areas.
- Read the draft policies, particularly those related to pumping fees, penalties, and mitigation measures. They're often linked on GSA websites or available through Farm Bureau.
- Attend a meeting or submit a comment. It doesn't have to be long. Just showing up matters. These are the policies that will determine what you can pump, what you'll pay, and whether your well qualifies for help.
- Talk to your neighbors. They are going through this just like you, and some may not know where to start. Start the conversations.

This is the real work of water leadership. Across the Tulare Lake subbasin, landowners, neighbors, and community members are putting in the time. They're showing up to meetings, wrestling with policies, and asking the hard questions. It's not always easy, but it matters. Because the Valley is worth it. The people are worth it. And every step we take now helps shape a future we can stand behind.

Julie Martella is a water consultant working across the Tulare Lake Subbasin to support SGMA implementation, stakeholder engagement, and community-based outreach.

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